doves and olive branches

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doves and olive branches

by Intensely_Reading

Summary

He turns to Mydei, letting a gentle smile curve on his lips. Mydei's eyes narrow to slits.

"Hello there," Phainon greets softly. He crouches down, inching closer. Mydei doesn't budge, only tenses like a tightly coiled spring. "My name is Phainon. You're Mydeimos, right?"

Mydei doesn't respond, lips pressed tightly shut. Phainon's smile wavers, chest squeezing tight.

"No one's going to hurt you here," he murmurs, extending his arm out. Mydei growls. Fear flashes through his eyes for a fleeting second, but it's enough to have Phainon freezing in place, breath catching in his throat.

(A mishap at the Abyss of Fate leaves Mydei a child whose only memories are of the Sea of Souls.)

Notes

We're in a canon divergence/canon universe where they're all real because I said so.

Bless Aerynn for being so patient with this one. We saw the end of Amphoreus' story before I finished this story 🥲

See the end of the work for more notes

There is a child in Mydei's chambers. A child that bears a striking resemblance to Mydei himself: golden hair, war tattoos, bright amber eyes. They snap to Phainon the moment he enters the room, and the wild expression on their face—on a face that young and this *familiar*—has Phainon faltering in his step, breath catching in his throat.

"What in the world?" he breathes. He turns to the two demigods in the room.

"Phainon," Aglaea greets, head tilting briefly toward him in acknowledgement before she redirects her attention to the child.

"Good morning, Snowy," Tribbie says, smile strained and tone worried while she wrings her hands.

"What happened?" Phainon asks, glancing between the child and the demigods. "Is that…"

"It is Mydeimos, yes," Aglaea says, lips curved in a frown. Mydei's eyes flicker to Aglaea, teeth bared. His back is pressed against the wall, gaze shifting between Aglaea, Phainon, and Tribbie like he's waiting for an attack.

"How did this happen?" Phainon asks, slowly, approaching the three of them. Mydei's tiny frame tenses, hands curling into fists. His chest tightens at the sight.

"Teacher and I were hoping you'd have some answers." Aglaea's eyes flicker to him, then to his left side. Phainon covers it from her line of sight, like somehow that will hide his wound from her. "As far as we know, Mydeimos developed a fever late last night after he returned from the Abyss of Fate with you. When he woke up, he had regressed into a child."

His brows furrow.

"Does he remember any of us?"

"No. De doesn't even know his own age, Snowy," Tribbie says, sounding distraught. Phainon grimaces. "He doesn't remember anything other than… other than—"

"The Sea of Souls?" Phainon asks gently. Tribbie bites her lip and nods. Mydei is fairly candid about most events in his life when asked; his time spent in the Sea of Souls is not one of them.

He turns to him, letting a gentle smile curve on his lips. Mydei's eyes narrow to slits.

"Hello there," Phainon greets softly. He crouches down, inching closer and wincing at the way it pulls his wound. Mydei doesn't budge, only tenses like a tightly coiled spring. "My name is Phainon. You're Mydeimos, right?"

Mydei doesn't respond, lips pressed tightly shut. Phainon's smile wavers, chest squeezing tight.

"No one's going to hurt you here," he murmurs, extending his arm out. Mydei growls, stance shifting. Fear flashes through his eyes for a fleeting second, but it's enough to have Phainon freezing in place, breath catching in his throat.

"Phainon,"—he looks back, meeting Aglaea's stern gaze—"did anything unusual happen during yesterday's expedition?"

Phainon purses his lips and gingerly rises, taking a deliberate step back. The expedition yesterday had started off normal—Phainon lobbing baseless insults at Mydei, Mydei giving it back just as good. They were only there to clear away any lingering black tide monsters and titankin in the Abyss of Fate; an easy enough task, so Phainon had proposed to make a competition out of it.

And then, they were ambushed.

Phainon skims his fingers along his left side, feeling the outlines of his bandages beneath his standard black shirt.

“We got into… an argument while clearing the temple,” Phainon admits carefully. He glances at Mydei. Guilt wraps his throat like a cold vice. “I accidentally activated some sort of blessing or mechanism there, and Mydei took the brunt of whatever prayer it was.”

He still remembers the strike of fear in Mydei’s eyes when the mechanism activated—overriding any anger from their argument moments before. He’d shoved himself between Phainon and the miracle orb right before it flashed a blinding blue. And when it was over, Mydei had stumbled in his step, spun around, and tore Phainon a new one for his carelessness—fussing over his wound.

They returned to Okhema shortly after. Mydei had forced him to visit Hyacine as soon as they arrived, Phainon had dragged Mydei to the baths after getting cleared, and then, they had dinner together before retiring for the night. Nothing happened out of the ordinary, and so Phainon, foolishly, thought it meant Mydei was fine.

Aglaea narrows her eyes in thought. She turns to Tribbie.

“Teacher, could you tell Trinnon to find Castorice and head to the Abyss of Fate?” she asks. “I’d like them to investigate this strange mechanism Phainon and Mydei came across there. This doesn’t sound like a standard blessing from Oronyx.”

“Of course, Aggy.” Tribbie casts one last glance at Mydei, expression anxious. “Is there anything else you need us to do?”

“Stay with Mydeimos.” Aglaea’s lips press to a thin line. “He’ll probably feel most at ease with you than with Phainon or me. We’ll be back soon, Teacher.”

“Okay.”

Aglaea inclines her head towards Phainon, then briskly strides out of the chambers. He hurries to follow.

“Where are we going?” he asks, sucking in a sharp breath when his wound suddenly pulses at the sharp movement. Aglaea slows her steps, letting him fall in line with her.

“We are going to the Kremnoan District,” she says. “You and I both know there is only one man who may have cared for Mydei when he was this young.”

By the time they return, Tribbie has coaxed Mydei into sitting on the kline, her small hands cupping one of his as she speaks to him in soft tones and gentle smiles. The moment the three of them step inside though, Mydei jerks his hand out of Tribbie's hold and plants his feet on the ground—eyes flicking warily between him, Aglaea, and Krateros.

"Titans…" Krateros curses, grey eyes widening at the sight. He rounds on Aglaea, glaring. "What is the meaning of this?"

"We are still trying to figure that out, Sir Krateros," Aglaea says, unfazed. "As far as we are aware, Mydeimos was afflicted with Oronyx's powers yesterday. He only remembers the memories he had at this age."

A shadow falls over Krateros' expression—harsh realization dawning on him like a sudden stab. He glances at Mydei with a complicated expression, then leans in closer to Aglaea.

"How did this happen?" he asks, tone low.

"A mishap during an expedition at the Abyss of Fate. I've already sent people to investigate it further." Aglaea waves a hand towards Mydeimos, expression neutral. "I had hoped that you might have some experience caring for Mydeimos in the years after he left the Sea of Souls, Krateros."

Krateros grimaces.

"Everyone who knew Prince Mydeimos the moment he stepped out of the titans-forsaken sea is long dead by now," he says, arms crossed. Phainon presses his lips together, glancing at Mydei. No matter how hard Tribbie tries, Mydei refuses to relax or sit back down. The vigilance cuts into his chest like its own kind of wound. "I only found him when he was already of age."

Aglaea frowns, sighing softly through her nose.

"I see. Then you are also just as out of your depth as the rest of us."

Krateros' brow twitches, a scowl twisting on his lips.

"I believe I am far more suited to take care of Mydeimos than any of you *Chrysos Heirs*," he hisses, spitting the words with blatant disdain. "I will take Mydeimos to the Kremnoan District. There are plenty of caretakers there who can watch over him until this curse passes—"

"No," Phainon blurts out. His eyes flick to Mydei again—how terribly young and small he looks—before meeting Krateros' glare head-on.

"No?" Krateros asks, a growl clipping the ends of the word. "And why is that, boy?"

"I'm the reason Mydei is like this," he says, hands clenching at his sides. He swallows his guilt down, letting it fester in his gut like a disease. "I should take responsibility of Mydei."

"If you are at fault, then you would do well to stay far away from the Prince."

"Snowy didn't mean for any of this to happen," Tribbie says, brows creased fretfully as she approaches the three of them. "De chose to protect Snowy yesterday."

"Are you saying it's Mydeimos' fault he's this way?"

“No!” She vehemently shakes her head, eyes wide.

“We’re Mydei’s best chance of returning back to normal, sir,” Phainon says. “Ladies Tribbie, Trinnon, and Trianne are well-versed in Oronyx’s prayers, and there’s no one better at investigating and collating information than Lady Aglaea.”

Krateros scoffs.

“You call her golden threads ‘collating’?”

“If there’s any solution to Mydei’s situation, Aglaea would be the first to know,” Phainon insists. “Besides, it’s not as if Mydei at this age would have any familiarity with the Kremnoan Detachment, sir.”

“He’d at least be among his people.”

“He couldn’t relax even with just Lady Aglaea and Lady Tribbie in the room with him,” he retorts. “What makes you think he’d relax around a group of new strangers?”

Krateros narrows his eyes, expression severe.

“I promise on my duty to Okhema and its people that we will do our best to return Mydei to normal.” His fingers twitch. He curls them into fists—hiding his desperation. “We’ll do everything we can to fix this. Right, Aglaea?”

Aglaea’s eyes slide toward him from where they’d been staring off to the side. She hums.

“You have our word. We will try everything we can, Lord Krateros,” she says, crossing her arms and tilting her head.

Krateros scowls.

“You lot have two days,” he growls. “If the Prince is still a child by then, I will be bringing him to the Kremnoan District.”

Phainon exhales and nods.

“Fine. We’ll reverse whatever blessing Oronyx placed on him by then.” He glances towards where Mydei had last stood and freezes, blood turning cold.

“Where’s De?!” Tribbie rushes over to the kline where Mydei had just stood, frantically circling it like Mydei’s somehow hiding by the kline.

“What?” Krateros turns and pales. “Were none of you watching him?!”

“You weren’t either,” Phainon accuses, voice high and reedy. His blood roars in his ears. Mydei had looked *terrified* when it was just him, Aglaea, and Tribbie in the room. What will happen if he ends up in Marmoreal Market? What if someone sees him for who he is and hurts him? Where would a child like him even *go*?

“Useless. All of you,” Krateros spits and strides out of the room.

Phainon makes to follow. A firm hand on his wrist pulls him back.

“He’s roaming the southern outskirts of Okhema,” Aglaea says calmly, brow raised when Phainon whips his head back. “He’s just outside the gate. There are titankin in the area. Take care not to aggravate your wound any more than you should, Phainon.”

Phainon straightens, then relaxes. Relief crashes upon him like a cold spray. He nods once.

“Thank you, Aglaea.”

Phainon tears through the whole of Okhema on his way to the southern gate—eyes peeled for any sign of a blond-haired child roaming the streets as he weaves through crowds of people out and about. By the time he arrives at the outskirts of the city, he can already hear the sounds of a battle: metal screeching against metal and bodies hitting the ground. The sounds make him sick with worry.

He sprints towards the noise, heart in his throat—his wound pulsing in protest. A titankin’s body crashes into the trees next to him, collapsing into a pile of rubble. Phainon jerks back and draws Dawnmaker.

There’s a crowd of five titankin charging towards the small child in the middle—weapons raised and ruthless. Phainon’s heart thrashes when Mydei grabs the nearest titankin’s blade and roars, throwing them into the others, sending three of them toppling. He’s bleeding gold all over, wounds flowing like a river. And yet, he doesn’t seem to notice—or doesn’t seem to care.

Mydei dodges a titankin’s strike, digs his hand into its chest, and pulls out a piece of marble like he’s pulling out a heart. He throws the corpse at the archer behind the crowd, then pummels the enemy closest to him. The brawler cracks down the middle, splintering to rubble.

One of the sword wielders swings, too fast for Mydei to dodge. Phainon lunges forward. He slips between Mydei and the enemy just in time to parry the strike aimed for his head, then shifts his grip and stabs straight for the chest. Mydei twists around, eyes wide and surprised. Phainon pulls his greatsword out and swings in a wide arc, forcing the rest of them back.

His stance shifts. A sword-wielder jabs forward, locking swords with him. Phainon twists their blade away, kicks the titankin hard enough to topple it, and digs Dawnmaker straight into the monster’s core. Next to him, Mydei slams into the last titankin, grabs its head, and pulls it cleanly off.

The field turns silent.

Phainon disperses his sword and immediately rushes to Mydei’s side, hand outstretched.

Mydei flinches back. Phainon stops. The glower on his face is equal parts wary, equal parts scared.

Phainon swallows. Slowly, he lowers himself so he’s eye-level with Mydei.

“At least let me check on your wounds,” he says, voice soft.

Mydei narrows his eyes.

“No need,” he says. His voice is terribly soft, raspy with disuse. Phainon’s lips twist into a frown. His hands clench.

“What do you mean ‘no need’?”

“I won’t die,” Mydei says.

“But you’re hurt.”

“They’ll heal.”

Phainon bites the inside of his cheek, chest aching. He closes his eyes, exhales, then opens them again. Mydei is watching him—eyes bright and perceptive. He looks so young; it makes his apathy so much worse.

“I won’t hurt you.” He extends his hand, close enough for Mydei to take. Mydei steps back. “I promise. I just want to make sure you’re okay.”

Mydei stills—gaze flicking between his hand and his face. The fear persists, longer this time. It dawns on him, then, that this may be the first time someone’s tried to touch Mydei without the intent to kill him. That singular thought sickens him. Phainon purses his lips together and patiently waits.

Minutes pass by. Mydei’s gaze stays on his face, the fear shifting into caution, then curiosity, then apprehension. Slowly, he places his hand in Phainon’s, the cool metal of Mydei’s gauntlets pressing against his skin. Mydei’s hand is smaller than he’s used to—maybe two-thirds the size he remembers. It’s sobering; every one of young Mydei’s actions is awfully sobering.

Gently, Phainon pulls him in, letting Mydei decide if he wants to step closer. He brushes his bangs out of his face, fingers combing through his hair for any bumps. Mydei shudders, eyes squeezing shut. His breath comes out short, anxious. Phainon’s teeth sink deeper into his cheek. His hands flutter over Mydei’s form, keeping his touch brief. Despite the golden blood splattered over his clothing, Phainon can’t find any wounds. Either he’s already healed from them, or he died before Phainon arrived.

He drops his hands. Mydei’s shoulders relax.

“Do you know your name?” Phainon murmurs.

Mydei nods.

“My name is Mydeimos.”

“Who told you?”

“A woman.” Mydei’s brows pinch. “She appears every time I die. She always finds me and leads me back from the Sea of Souls.”

Oh. Phainon’s heart squeezes tight. Even in death, his mother had tried for him.

“Did she tell you anything else?” he asks.

“She said I am the Crown Prince of Castrum Kremnos.”

“She’s right.”

Mydei stares at him oddly, eyes squinting.

“Who is she?” he asks. “You act like you know her.”

Phainon laughs—the sound a short little huff.

“I don’t,” he says. “I wish I did though.”

Mydei frowns. The conversation lulls.

“Sister Tribbie said I used to be older,” he says, speaking Tribbie’s name like he’s unsure of his own words. “Does the lady no longer appear when I die?”

Phainon blinks. His throat constricts. The smile he forces is wider than his emotions feel.

“I don’t know,” he admits honestly. “Older you doesn’t usually mention the people you pass on your way back to the living.”

Mydei goes quiet, a shadow falling over his face. He crosses his arms, holding himself like he’s trying to keep warm. Phainon’s arms twitch. He wants to wrap his arms around Mydei—hold him tight enough to show him the warmth that comes with touch, but he doesn’t think this younger version of him would appreciate it. His older version rarely let Phainon coddle him as is.

Phainon sighs and stands. A sharp pang radiates from his wound while he straightens. He sucks in a breath through gritted teeth, hands flying to his side. Mydei’s eyes flicker to him, honing on his side.

“Are you hungry?” Phainon diverts, breathless. Mydei’s gaze rises to meet his, eyes narrowing. “Neither of us has had breakfast yet.”

Mydei stares. Phainon waits for his pain to dull to an ache and for his breath to return before he says, “Come on. Let’s go eat.”

They take the side roads back to Marmoreal Palace, Phainon leading them down alleyways and back streets where fewer people roam. Mydei follows just a step behind, shadowing him—not too far, not too close.

He glances back, watching Mydei take in the outer edges of the city—eyes large and wary as he scans their surroundings like a wounded animal. The hyper-vigilance is learned, that much Phainon can tell. There’s no reason a child should be this guarded unless they’ve had no one else to rely on but themselves.

His lips press into a thin line. He wants to take Mydei’s hand, promise him that he’s safe—that Phainon would sooner destroy the world before he let anything happen to him, child or not. But Mydei hadn’t even let him check for wounds without him coaxing—hadn’t let him touch him at all.

So, he tamps the feeling down and guides them through Okhema, looking back every now and then for his own sake. When they reach the Palace, he leads past the main baths and down side hallways until they reach the kitchen specifically for the Chrysos Heirs.

“Do you have a preference for food?” Phainon asks, opening the shelves for something to eat. As the heir who uses the kitchen the most, Mydei is particularly stringent about keeping it well-stocked. None of them has ever had to worry about going hungry since he took over cooking duties.

He cracks open the cooler, scanning the shelves, then glances at Mydei.

“You can sit,” he says, gesturing to stools next to the kitchen island. Mydei hesitates before gingerly settling into one of them.

“What’s a preference?” Mydei asks.

Phainon pauses, hands stilling.

“It’s something you like more than others,” he says. “Is there anything you want to eat right now?”

Mydei stares blankly, as if the idea of choosing something to eat is foreign to him. Phainon bites the inside of his cheek and pastes a gentle smile on his face.

“It’s alright. I’ll choose for us,” he says, reaching for their bundles of berries and a pomegranate. His hands are stiff as he washes the fruit, chest squeezing tight. He knows of the things Mydei has experienced—has heard Mydei mention them well enough. But the conditions he lived through during the first decade of his life hadn’t *truly* occurred to Phainon—at least, not in this sort of mundane capacity—until now, while he’s witnessing the effects first-hand.

He lets the water run long enough for his breathing to steady and his misery to settle before shaking off the excess water and dumping the berries in a bowl. He cracks the pomegranate open, scoops out the arils, and sets it in front of Mydei.

“It’s fruit,” Phainon says softly when Mydei only stares. “They’re sweet. You’ll like these small ones.”

He nudges it closer. Cautiously, Mydei pinches one of the pomegranate arils, turning it in his finger.

“Did older me like the fruits?” he asks quietly, the words raspy at the edges. Phainon smiles.

“Yeah.” He nods at the aril in Mydei’s hands. “The pomegranates were your favorite.”

Mydei’s expression pinches. He tentatively bites into the aril, licks his lips, and eats the whole thing. And then, he eats another—just as tentative, just as savored.

“There’s plenty in the fridge if you want more,” Phainon coaxes gently. “Eat as much as you’d like.”

“What about you?” Mydei asks.

“I’m fine.” His lips quirk. “I’m not that fond of pomegranates. That and the berries are all for you.”

Mydei’s eyes flicker across his face, brows furrowing. His next bite is still just as tentative.

Phainon turns, rummaging through their cupboards for a few more ingredients. He dices a shallot, grates a few tomatoes, then cracks a handful of eggs in a bowl, beating them together.

He works quickly, following the steps of a recipe he knows by heart. Once the eggs are cooked and the strapatsada tastes up to standard, Phainon kills the fire and gently sets the pan on the kitchen island, placing it far enough away from Mydei and the bowl of fruit he's picking at.

"Careful," Phainon warns, setting a plate of pita down next to it. "It's hot."

He grabs a piece of pita and scoops the strapatsada on it. Mydei watches his movements, his stare intense and terribly hungry.

"Try some," Phainon encourages, biting into their late breakfast. He watches Mydei take a piece of pita and attempt to mimic him. Mydei's eyes widen the moment he takes a bite, swallowing roughly before immediately going for more.

Phainon smiles, finishing off his own piece. He pushes the pita plate closer to Mydei, his chest warming at the sight of Mydei digging in without reservation.

Mydei makes it through half of the strapatsada before he stops, glancing at Phainon with a slight frown.

"Why aren't you eating?"

"I'm fine," Phainon assures. Mydei's frown deepens. "You can finish it all, Mydeimos."

"But you're hungry too."

Phainon falters. His eyes rove Mydei's form, the golden blood on his skin, the gauntlets set aside while he eats, the winding start of the war tattoos he bears when he's older. All of it makes his heart ache. He's years too late to save Mydei from the childhood horrors of his past; they happened long before Phainon knew him. But having the chance to pamper this version of Mydei while he's under a time curse feels just as satisfying—just as real.

If only Mydei would *let him*.

"I won't eat without you."

Phainon snorts.

"Bargaining, are we?" he teases, reaching for the pita. "You always made it so difficult to take care of you."

Mydei's eyes narrowed.

"I can handle myself."

Phainon hums.

"I know you can," he says somberly. He scrapes at the strapatsada, the tomatoes soaking the bread. "Can I wipe up the blood on you?"

"I can do it myself."

“And if I insisted?” Phainon asks, watching the other. Mydei’s shoulders stiffen, eyes sharpening. Phainon leans back from the kitchen island and exhales slow—resigned. “I won’t. I promise.”

Mydei’s eyes don’t leave him. Phainon finishes up his piece of pita and brushes his hands clean.

“We’ll finish up here, then head to the Twilight Courtyard,” Phainon says, painfully aware of the way his wound continues to ache. “I wanted to wipe up the blood on you so we don’t give Hyacine a heart attack when we arrive.”

“Hyacine?”

Phainon smiles.

“Our resident healer.”

“You know, when I saw Lady Aglaea’s message in the Heirs’ group chat, I wasn’t completely sure what to make of it,” Hyacine says, watching Mydei interact with one of the chimeras helping in the Courtyard today. “Not that I thought Lady Aglaea was lying, but…”

“Yeah.” Phainon nods. Mydei’s eyes widen when the chimera nuzzles against his hand, and Phainon feels his chest melt. “It’s my fault he’s this way.”

Hyacine shakes her head, rewinding the bandages around his torso.

“I’m sure it wasn’t.” She ties the bandages off and casts a healing circle around him. “Now, are you going to tell me how you got this wound, or do I have to drag it out of you? You and Lord Mydei were pretty mum about it yesterday.”

“Ah.” Phainon rubs his nape sheepishly, tearing his eyes away from Mydei’s small smile to meet Hyacine’s unimpressed gaze. “Mydei and I got into a fight.”

Hyacine’s brows raise.

“Lord Mydei did this?”

“No!” Phainon denies, eyes wide. “No, no. We… um… got ambushed during our expedition yesterday. And the wound was a… calculated risk that Mydei didn’t appreciate.”

“I see.” Her eyes slide back to Mydei. The chimera has curled up in his lap now. Mydei pets it gently. His movements are clunky and stiff, like he’s not used to acting in this way. Phainon purses his lips against a smile. “Can I check on him?”

He blinks.

“I’m not his ward,” he says, patting himself on the back for sounding only slightly resigned about it.

“You act like you are,” Hyacine says, smiling exasperatedly. She stands from her seat and slowly approaches Mydei. Mydei’s eyes snap up to her as soon as she moves, watching her with the same level of tensed wariness he’s had during all his previous interactions. Hyacine exchanges a few words with him before Mydei slowly pushes the chimera out of his lap, looking terribly apologetic about it.

The chimera chirps and follows them both as they walk back towards Phainon.

“You can sit here, next to Phainon.” Mydei settles carefully on the clinic bench a respectable distance from Phainon. “Now, Mydei, I’m going to check on your vitals, which means I need to touch you. Is that alright?”

Mydei’s expression flickers. Reluctantly, he nods.

“You can have Chirara sit with you through the check-up,” Hyacine offers, flipping open her notebook on the counter with her first aid equipment. Chirara the chimera chirps, pressing up against Mydei’s leg.

He hesitates, only for a moment, before leaning down to pick the chimera up. Chirara shifts, tucking its legs underneath its body and curling its tail around itself, head pressed against Mydei’s stomach. Phainon watches Mydei comb his fingers through its fur, his shoulders relaxing bit by bit.

“I’m going to touch your neck now to feel your pulse, okay?” Hyacine says. Mydei nods. Gently, her hands slip around the side of his neck. He visibly swallows, his hand faltering its pets. Chirara trills and butts his hand until he resumes petting. “Your pulse is strong as always, Mydei.”

“As always?” Mydei asks, his words a thin murmur. “Do I come to you often?”

“Yes,” Hyacine says. eyes soft. “Only when it gets really bad though. But sometimes Phainon drags you for routine check-ups too. You tend to ramble when you’re injured.”

“Oh.”

“I’m going to move my hands to your back and chest, okay?”

Mydei nods. Hyacine brings her hands to the left side of Mydei’s chest, feeling for his heartbeat. Her other hand settles across the widest part of his back where his lungs lie.

“Breathe in deep for me?”

Mydei sucks in a shaky inhale.

“Good,” she praises. “Once more?”

Hyacine checks his hearing, vision, temperature, and blood pressure. Then, she directs him to scale and measures his weight and his height, offering encouragement and initiating small talk whenever Mydei seems to tense up. When she’s done, she brings Mydei back to the seat next to Phainon, setting Chirara back in Mydei’s lap.

“You’re a bit malnourished and sleep-deprived from what I can tell, Mydei,” Hyacine says, scanning her notes. Her brows furrow. “You’re shorter than most kids your age, but other than that, you seem to be healthy, if not more active than most.”

“What’s the confusion then?” Phainon asks. Hyacine glances at him, then at Mydei, and purses her lips.

“It’s just strange is all,” Hyacine says, placing a hand on her chin. “Lord Mydei didn’t show any signs of sleep deprivation or malnourishment when I checked him yesterday. It seems whatever affliction Oronyx placed upon you genuinely reversed time on even your body’s condition. I can sense a lot of stress and exhaustion in you. But Lord Mydei didn’t have those same markers yesterday.”

Phainon frowns. He turns to Mydei, who looks almost thoughtful at Hyacine’s words. His hands twitch to reach out, gut twisting itself into uncomfortable knots.

“I’ll get in contact with Professor Anaxa,” Hyacine says, scribbling something down in her notebook. “He might have some insight into this curse. And, if nothing else, it’ll be of interest to him. Your body seems to have reverted entirely back to the state it was in when you were this age, Mydei.”

“Do you have any suggestions on how to make Mydei less stressed, Hyacine?” Phainon asks. Hyacine’s expression softens. She glances at Mydei, a sad smile on her face.

“Is there anything we can do to make you feel more comfortable here?” she asks, lowering herself so she’s eye-level with him.

Mydei purses his lips, then shakes his head.

“This has been nice,” he admits, voice quiet enough that Phainon has to lean close to hear. “The last thing I remember before waking in that strange room was drowning in the Sea of Souls. Being here is much better than the Sea.”

Phainon sucks in a sharp breath. Hyacine’s expression falls.

“I’m sorry, Mydei,” she murmurs, her words so quiet, Phainon almost feels like he’s intruding. “I’m glad you’re here with us then. Is it alright if I give you a hug?”

Mydei stills, then seemingly forces himself to relax in front of Hyacine. Slowly, he nods—the movement so slight, Phainon almost wonders if it was an accident. But then, Hyacine is wrapping her arms around Mydei, her hold loose enough for him to push away. And Mydei just… lets her.

And he knows it’s terrible, but he still feels the way his gut twinges—a stone dropping in his stomach that echoes like jealousy. His lips press into a thin line, and he averts his gaze.

“Thank you for letting me run a check-up on you,” he hears Hyacine say. She flits past her peripheral vision, opening one of her cabinets and digging through it, before producing a piece of hard candy in her hands. “Here! A treat for following my instructions so well.”

“What is it?”

“It’s candy,” Hyacine says, winking. “I remember older you having a bit of a sweet tooth.”

Mydei stares at the candy, taking it from her hands and turning it over. Hyacine slips a hand through Mydei’s hair and gently ruffles it. Mydei hardly flinches.

“I’ll let you both know if I hear anything from Professor Anaxa,” she says, glancing at Phainon with a small smile. “Both of you should be good to go now. So, shoo! It’s a wonderful day today. Take advantage of it.”

Phainon plasters a smile back, ignoring his own childish bitterness. He stands, dusting off his pants.

“Thank you for your help, Hyacine.”

“Of course! Always happy to help.”

Post-Hyacine’s check-up, Phainon takes it upon himself to cook a feast for Mydei: seared lamb chops, stuffed eggplants, salad, soup, skewers, and meatballs. There’s enough food to feed the rest of the Heirs still in Okhema too, and Phainon makes a mental note to message them about the leftovers—*after* Mydei has had his fill.

“Eat as much as you’d like,” he encourages, settling across from Mydei at the dinner table. The other stares at the spread, eyes flickering between each dish. A furrow creases between his brows.

“There’s so much food,” he says, hands grasping the table tightly.

“It’s alright if you don’t finish everything,” Phainon says. “Whatever you can’t eat, we’ll save.”

He starts serving himself, and after a moment, Mydei follows suit—taking a conservative amount from each dish. Phainon watches him taste each one, his eyes lighting up like stars every time, and smiles behind his own bowl.

After his first round, Mydei takes one more lamb chop and a few skewers and asks, “Why are you hurt?”

Phainon pauses mid-bite.

“Me?”

Mydei nods.

“Ah. It’s nothing major.”

“But it’s bleeding,” he says. Even at this age, he’s still able to sound supremely unimpressed.

Phainon sheepishly laughs and rubs his nape.

“We got ambushed,” he admits. “Older you and I. We were in the Temple of Oronyx. A titankin was about to kill you, so I pushed you out of the way.”

Mydei had dispatched that titankin with a scary sort of ferocity after that, amber eyes flashing in anger. And then, he’d rounded on Phainon and shouted at him within an inch of his life for his actions.

“You took the hit for me?” Mydei asks, brows pinching together.

“Yeah. It was a dirty move by the titankin,” Phainon says. “And you would’ve been in a lot worse shape if I hadn’t taken the hit.”

Mydei glances at his side, where the wound lies behind his black shirt. A frown twists on his face.

“But I can’t die,” he says, sounding painfully confused.

Phainon feels his expression twist into a half-smile, half-grimace. Mydei had said the same thing yesterday too: *I can’t die, Deliverer. Spilling my blood is nothing compared to yours.*

“If I can prevent it,” he begins, just as he’d said yesterday, “then I’d rather not see you die, Mydei.”

Mydei had called him a child for that—for disliking his impermanent deaths, for uselessly protecting him. *Actions like these could get you killed, Deliverer. I, at least, come back.*

How am I *the child for wanting to protect you?*

“I can heal faster than you,” Mydei says, sounding more and more upset. “You should’ve let me take the hit.”

Phainon snorts dryly, annoyance crawling underneath his skin

“You never really changed, have you, Mydei?” he mutters, more to himself than to the child in front of him. He shakes his head. “Your immortality is not a chip you should play because you can. You’re more than just a weapon to be used, you know.”

Mydei’s frown deepens, an uncomfortable expression on his face. He averts his gaze down to his plate and picks at his food. The reaction makes Phainon feel worse.

“I act like my older self?” Mydei suddenly blurts out, the topic change so jarring, Phainon has to reorient his own thoughts. He blinks, pursing his lips and silently letting the change in topics slide.

“More like your older self acts like you,” he says ruefully. “You’re still just as stubborn, just as tough, and just as hyper-independent.”

He supposes it’s hard not to view your life as meaningless when you’ve spent your formative years dying a thousand different ways, only to come back to the same hell. It’s hard not to view yourself as a weapon when it’s all you’ve known how to be since you were born. But Mydei has always been so much more than that.

“You care too much in the same way, too,” Phainon murmurs, propping his chin on his hand. “It’s how you ended up like this.”

“What do you mean?”

“We were arguing about my wound,” Phainon says. “I was angry that you wanted me to just let you die. You were angry that I let myself get hurt for you. We were distracted when I bumped into that Oronyx miracle orb.” The clicking of gears locking into place. That stab of fear in Mydei’s eyes. Phainon bites the inside of his cheek. “You didn’t think, you just acted. Pushed me out of the way and took the brunt of whatever power Oronyx cast.”

It's ironic, really, if he thinks about it. One of the few times Phainon forces Mydei to accept his protection, Mydei gets cursed in Phainon's place and gives it back tenfold. Realistically, *he* should've been the one cursed, not Mydei. But Mydei has always cared too much about things that aren't himself.

"It makes sense that I would take the fall though," Mydei says, voice firm. "I can't die."

Phainon laughs, short and curt.

"And we're back to the same argument again," he says, biting back his unhappiness. "It's fine though. It doesn't matter. We'll definitely find a way to return you back to normal, Mydei. But, while you're like this, you can trust me to take care of you. I promise."

Mydei scans his face—eyes looking far too piercing than any child's eyes should be. He goes back to his food, finishes up the rest on his plate, and doesn't respond.

"Here. Lady Aglaea found some of my old clothes from when I was younger for you." Phainon hands over a bright yellow tunic and soft purple cotton pants for Mydei to take.

Mydei looks upon the clothes with something close to disdain. The sight makes Phainon laugh.

"We can go clothes shopping tomorrow," he promises, amusement curling on his lips. "For now, you should change out of your dirty clothes and head to bed."

Mydei grimaces at the tunic and pants. Slowly, reluctantly, he peels off his day-clothes—all of them still stained with golden blood and grime. Phainon turns his back to Mydei, busying himself with smoothing out the wrinkles and fluffing up the pillows. He yawns wide and sighs, glancing out at the eternal day. It's just barely Curtain-Fall Hour, and he already feels exhausted.

"I'm done," Mydei says. He glances back. Phainon had been a little older than Mydei is now when he first arrived in Okhema, so the shirt practically swallows his form, the sleeves reaching the middle of his arm. It makes him look terribly small, and it hits Phainon—not for the first time today—just how much Mydei's experienced at such a young age. His arms twitch to hold Mydei in his arms. "What now?"

"Now, it's time to sleep."

Mydei stares blankly up at him.

"Sleep?"

Phainon's smile drops, a terrible sense of foreboding coming over him.

"Yes. It's time to rest for the day." He pats the bed, urging Mydei to climb on. Mydei's brows pinch, a confused expression on his face that makes the ground underneath Phainon feel unsteady.

"How do you…" he trails off, unsure.

“How do you sleep?” Phainon hedges, holding his breath.

Mydei’s jaw clenches. He nods. Phainon’s heart drops.

“Do you know what sleep is?” he asks tentatively.

“It’s like dying, but it doesn’t hurt and you don’t die,” Mydei says. Phainon’s lips curl down into a pained frown. “I’ve never had to sleep.”

“Never had to sleep or never lived long enough to need it?” Phainon presses. Mydei presses his lips together, that same wary look from this morning tightening his face, and Phainon bites his tongue.

“Alright… alright.” He runs a hand through his hair, glancing at Mydei with a somber smile even while his hands clench. “Here. Come to bed.”

Mydei shuffles over. Phainon pulls the covers down.

“Lie down.”

He lies down on his back, stock-still and watching Phainon quietly. Phainon brings the covers over him, smoothing out the wrinkles and tucking him in.

“Close your eyes,” Phainon murmurs. Mydei bites his lip, trepidation seeping in his eyes. Phainon swallows roughly, biting the inside of his cheek. “Don’t worry. I’ll be here. Nothing will happen to you, Mydei. Promise.”

Mydei’s hands clench over the blankets. Phainon crosses the room to draw the curtains close until only a thin stream of light seeps into the room, then pulls a chair next to Mydei’s bedside. Mydei’s eyes are still wide open. Phainon sighs.

“Am I strong, Mydeimos?” he asks. Mydei’s brows furrow.

“Yes,” he says, softly.

“I’d like to think I am too.” He smiles ruefully. “I think I’m strong enough to fight off anything that might try to hurt you. And I will. I promise I will. I swear on my life. So, trust me when I say you’re safe here. You’re safe with me. You can rest here.”

Phainon would sooner die than let anything happen to Mydei.

“If I sleep, you will wake me if someone comes,” Mydei demands like a little prince.

“I will wake you if someone comes,” he promises solemnly.

“Okay.” Mydei exhales shakily. “Okay.”

“Close your eyes.”

Mydei closes his eyes, squeezing them tight. Phainon reaches over, brushing his bangs off his face, and feels Mydei shudder under his touch.

“Would it help if I sang a lullaby?”

“Lullaby?” Mydei asks, the word barely a whisper.

“A song to help you sleep.” Phainon lifts his hand, gripping it in his lap so he doesn’t try touching Mydei again. “My mother would sing to me when I was young. I still remember the tunes.”

All of Aedes Elysiae’s songs were folk songs: myths about the Time Titan, prayers to the Earth Titan, wishes for the Sky Titan—all of them relating to the harvest. It’s about the last thing Phainon still has left from his little farm town.

Mydei exhales, the breath shaky at the end.

“Okay.”

Phainon blinks, surprised, and smiles.

“Okay.”

Phainon jerks awake in his chair, the room loud with the terrible sound of heavy breathing and thrashing. He turns on the bedside lamp, heart in his throat, and squints. Mydei’s twitching in bed, fear pinching his expression, breaths coming out short and stuttered like the start of a panic attack. Phainon shoots forward, gripping Mydei’s shoulders and shaking him.

“Mydei,” he urges. “Mydei, wake up. You’re having a nightmare. Wake up.”

Mydei grabs his arm. The world violently tilts. His back hits the bed with startling force—knocking the wind out of him. Phainon wheezes, wound spasming. He just barely jerks out of the way of a clumsy punch and grabs Mydei’s shoulder again, holding tight.

“Mydei. Wake up.”

Mydei’s arm shoots out and hits him square in the chest, eyelids twitching. His breathing quickens—fighting an enemy Phainon cannot see nor kill. He grits his teeth, shaking Mydei harder, wincing when the other kicks his wounded side.

“Mydei. Come on,” he begs. “Wake up.”

Phainon splays his hand across the span of Mydei’s shoulders and drags him in, his arms locking in a restraining hug. Mydei gasps. His eyes shoot open, gaze hazy with soul-crushing fear. He thrashes in Phainon’s hold, breaths hitching into the start of sobs, and Phainon feels his heart break at the sound. He shifts his arms, guiding Mydei’s head against his chest, and wraps his other arm around his waist until he’s pressed flush against him.

“You’re okay. You’re okay,” Phainon murmurs, forcing his own fear down the longer Mydei squirms. “You’re fine. You’re safe. You’re okay, Mydei. It’s just me.” He slips his fingers through Mydei’s hair, rubbing soothing circles against his back. “It’s just me.”

A broken sob leaves Mydei. Phainon hushes him, pressing his face against his hair. Panic grips his throat, cold and overwhelming.

“You’re okay, you’re okay,” he repeats like a mantra, empty words falling on deaf ears. “You’re okay, Mydei. You’re okay. You’re safe. I promise. You’re safe.”

Mydei trembles in his hold, tiny hands scrabbling for his shirt. It feels like hours before he finally, finally, calms down—the shivering slowing to sporadic twitching, his soft cries quietening to sniffles. He feels small hands fist into his shirt, Mydei burying his face further into his sternum. Phainon squeezes him just a little tighter, cupping his head and curling his body around him.

Mydei’s breath shudders, catching on his lingering fear, but he’s no longer crying. Not anymore. And Phainon feels he breathes easy again—taking shaky, full breaths of air.

“Titans,” he mutters, heart thundering against his chest. Mydei shifts in his hold, burrowing closer to him like he’s trying to carve a space in his chest for himself. His breaths slow back to a relaxed crawl. Phainon pulls the kicked covers over both of them, unwilling to let Mydei go.

“You’re okay,” he mumbles, curling around Mydei. He takes a deep breath, blood still roaring in his ears. “You’re okay.”

He falls asleep to the sound of Mydei’s quiet breathing next to his ear.

Phainon opens his eyes to Mydei lifting his shirt. It takes a few moments for him to register that Mydei’s awake and still in his arms. And then, another few to realize he’s lifting his shirt.

“What are you doing?” he croaks.

Mydei looks up, face tense, a severe frown on his lips.

“You’re bleeding.”

Phainon blinks slowly. He looks down. Mydei’s pulled his shirt up high enough to check his bandages. Directly above where his wound lies is a faint stain of gold.

“Oh.” Phainon sighs. “It’s fine. I’ll change out the bandages after a bath.”

“You have bruises too.” Mydei gently presses a finger to a purpling bruise on his stomach, expression distraught. “Is it because of me?”

“Huh?”

“Did I hurt you while I was asleep?” he asks, the wrinkle between his brows deepening. “You were on the chair when I fell asleep. Did I hurt you?”

“It’s not your fault,” Phainon assures. His arms are still wrapped around him; he combs his fingers through Mydei’s hair. Mydei stiffens like a statue, and Phainon immediately stops. “You were having a nightmare.”

“I hurt you.”

“Not on purpose,” Phainon corrects gently. He smiles. “It’s fine, Mydei. I’ll survive.”

Mydei’s eyes sharpen. He pulls out of Phainon’s arms and moves to his drawers, opening them and rifling through. When he doesn’t find what he’s looking for, Mydei scowls and hurries to the next set of drawers.

“What are you looking for?” Phainon asks, gingerly sitting up. His wound twinges. The bruises are tender, but the pain is miles better than it had been yesterday morning.

Mydei glances at him once, then goes back to his sifting. He abandons that set of drawers, a sour frown on his face, and moves to the armor. Phainon watches Mydei’s eyes light up when he pulls out a first aid kit.

“I hurt you,” he says, making his way back on the bed. “I’ll change your bandages.”

Phainon raises a brow, stuck between touched and exasperated.

“There’s no need to, Mydei. I can do it myself—”

“I want to.” Mydei takes out a pair of scissors and cuts off one of the wraps. “I hurt you. I should take responsibility.”

“It wasn’t your fault,” Phainon murmurs. He reaches out—to comfort him, or halt his hands—then thinks better of it. “You’ll have to do more than aggravate a wound in the middle of a night terror to do damage to me, Mydei.”

Mydei’s expression sours. He unwraps the bandages, his movements slow and unfamiliar, and doesn’t respond. Phainon exhales and waits, letting the other slowly pull away the old wraps. Once he’s got all the bandages off, Mydei’s even more careful with the gauze pad, his small hands slowly peeling away the tape—stiffening each time he moves a little too quickly.

“Does it hurt?” Mydei asks, sounding uncharacteristically small.

“No.”

Mydei glances up, eyes wide and guilty. Phainon’s heart clenches. He smiles for Mydei.

“It doesn’t hurt,” he repeats.

“Are you lying?”

Phainon blinks.

“Why would I lie?” he asks, confused. Mydei frowns. The answer seems to displease him. He looks down and pulls off the last bit of tape.

His wound is an angry red in the weak light, inflamed and ugly. A faint trickle of blood oozes out where it still has yet to scab over. But there isn’t any pus leaking or a sign of an infection. Perhaps one more visit to Hyacine and her healing circle and he’ll be fully healed.

Mydei takes a new gauze pad out from the kit.

“Have you ever bandaged a wound?” Phainon asks. Mydei glances at him, then looks away.

“No.”

“You need to disinfect it first,” Phainon says gently. He pulls the first-aid kit closer and pulls out a rag from the first-aid kit and the small bottle of cheap alcohol Mydei keeps in it. Then, he pours some over the rag and wipes at his wound. Prickling pain shoots up the moment the rag hits his skin, and Phainon hisses, jaw clenching tight. He moves quickly and efficiently, wiping up the excess blood and cleaning it as best as he can.

Mydei watches, then places the gauze pad over the injury. He pulls out the medical tape, brows pinched, and attempts to rip pieces off, each one jagged and uneven. Phainon huffs, amused, and stops him before he decimates all of the tape.

“Mydei, it’s okay,” he assures, plucking the roll of tape from his hand. “How about this, I wrap myself this time around, and you watch. And then, the next time I need to change my bandages, you can do it then. Okay?”

Mydei makes a face.

“You already unwrapped my bandages for me. That’s more than enough,” he coaxes. He reaches out, brushing Mydei’s bangs out of his face. Mydei startles away, eyes wide. Phainon freezes as well and slowly retracts his hand.

“Fine,” Mydei says quietly. He gathers all the dirty bandages he’d left on the floor and silently throws them in the trash. Phainon watches him, lips pursed, and sighs.

He takes off the gauze pad Mydei had placed and searches through the first-aid kit. Hyacine had given them both a bottle of healing salves in the hopes that they’d use them. Phainon *knows* Mydei barely used his on the account of not truly needing it. It’d only been for small wounds and cuts—injuries that would disappear in an hour with Mydei’s healing capabilities—and while this wasn’t quite a small wound, it would have to do.

He finds the salve tucked in the very bottom of the kit and fishes it out, staring at it from under the light. Just as he’s about to open the bottle, Mydei’s door opens and Hyacine barges in.

“I got a message from Mydei that you’re hurt,” Hyacine says, hurrying over.

“What?” Phainon glances at Mydei, meeting his serious expression. He lowers his gaze. His teleslate is in Mydei’s hands. “Oh.”

“Are you okay?” Hyacine asks, opening her medical supplies bag. She eyes his wound and sighs. “Good, good. I see you’re changing out your bandages now. Why is it bleeding again?”

“I did it,” Mydei says, padding towards the bed, a grim set to his expression. “I hurt him.”

“It was an accident,” Phainon hurries to clarify. “It wasn’t Mydei’s fault. He was thrashing through a nightmare is all.”

“I hit him.”

“And I told you it takes more than a few hits to take me out,” he says, trying for a smile.

Hyacine purses her lips and nods.

“Thank you for telling me the truth, Mydei.” She smiles kindly at him, patting him once on the shoulder. “I’ll handle it from here.”

She opens her bag, taking out her own roll of tapes, bandages, and gauze pads. A healing circle appears around Phainon before Hyacine takes out a cotton ball and her antiseptic.

“This is going to sting,” Hyacine warns. “What do you guys have planned for today?”

“Nothing yet—” Phainon sucks in a sharp breath, the antiseptic burning against his wound. He grits his teeth. “We’re just waiting for Castorice and Trinnon.”

Hyacine hums.

“You should probably think about getting Mydei some new clothes,” she says, eyeing Mydei’s outfit amusedly. Mydei’s lips twist into what looks almost like a pout before he looks away.

“They’re Phainon’s old clothes,” Mydei mutters, ears red.

Hyacine laughs, though not unkindly.

“Of course they are. Phainon’s always had an eccentric clothing taste.” He makes an affronted sound. Hyacine does one last wipe around the wound before throwing the cotton ball away. She slips on a few gloves and opens up a jar of some sort of thick ointment. “Your wound should close up by tomorrow if you take it easy today, Phainon. No sudden titankin fights or spars.”

“What do you take me for?” he asks, voice tightening unconsciously while Hyacine smears a generous amount of the ointment over his side.

“An unruly patient given you undid all my hard work yesterday.”

“That—”

“That was my fault too, Lady Hyacine,” Mydei murmurs guiltily.

Hyacine pauses, glancing at Mydei in surprise.

“Phainon’s just fine, Mydei,” she says. “How is it your fault?”

“I snuck away and fought some titankin.”

Hyacine blinks, then sighs.

“I guess I should’ve expected that,” she says wryly.

“I couldn’t just stand aside and let Mydei fight alone,” he says.

“You usually can’t. Neither you nor Mydei ever stands down,” Hyacine says. She presses a clean gauze pad to Phainon’s side and starts neatly taping it down. “Well, Mydei. Can I trust you to make sure Phainon won’t get himself any more hurt?”

“I’m not a child,” Phainon grumbles.

Mydei nods solemnly.

“Yes, Lady Hyacine.”

“Just Hyacine, De,” Hyacine says. “And thank you.”

She gently pats Mydei’s head, fingers slipping through the strands. Mydei blinks, eyes widening the slightest bit. Phainon watches the exchange, then lowers his gaze to his hands, a frown curving on his lips.

“Have you heard anything from Professor Anaxa, Hyacine?” he asks, clenching his hands before looking back up at Hyacine.

“Nothing yet.” She tapes down one end of the bandage, then starts wrapping it tightly around Phainon’s torso. “He said he’d look into it though. This curse was powerful enough to erase Lord Mydei’s memories too, so the Professor will want to figure out what happened. We’ll probably hear something from him by tomorrow.”

“Good.”

Hyacine nods.

“And… done! You’re good to go, Phainon.”

“Thank you for your help, Hyacine.”

“Of course! It’s what I’m here for.” She snaps her bag shut, hanging it in the crook of her arm. “Let me know if there’s anything else you two need from me.” She ruffles Phainon’s hair, much to his fond exasperation and complaints. Hyacine laughs and pulls back. When she ruffles Mydei’s hair in parting, she’s much more gentle, an open smile on her lips.

Mydei doesn’t flinch away, hardly even reacts to the touch—only shyly smiles back, small and subdued.

“Stay close to me, okay?” Phainon murmurs, slowing his steps so Mydei can keep up. He bites his lip, fingers twitching. It would be so much easier to just take Mydei’s hand while they walk through the thick of Marmoreal Market, but if the morning with Hyacine showed him anything, Mydei still doesn’t trust him. At least, not as much as he trusts Hyacine.

He supposes it makes sense. Between a warrior and a healer, it’s much easier to trust the healer isn’t out to hurt you. And, after all those years in the Sea of Souls dying and reviving just to die again, he can’t blame Mydei for being wary—for being more cautious than any child should be. But they spent the whole day together; is Phainon truly that untrustworthy? Is he that unreliable to Mydei?

He runs a hand through his hair, biting the inside of his cheek. That stab of fear in Mydei’s eyes flickers in his mind, the intensity of it before Mydei took the fall for *Phainon’s* mistake. He wasn’t reliable then, was he? And Mydei paid the price for Phainon’s blunders.

“Phainon?”

Phainon blinks, glancing down. Mydei's staring at him, amber eyes bright and keen. Phainon tilts his head.

"What is it?"

"You looked…" Mydei's brows furrow, "…upset."

"I'm okay," Phainon assures. Mydei's expression flattens, displeased. "We'll be heading into the marketplace soon. There's going to be a lot of people, so make sure you stick close, okay?"

Mydei nods.

"Okay." Phainon exhales and steps into the market.

It's barely Action Hour, but the plaza is already full of life—hawkers advertising their wares, money changing hands, groups of people chatting and laughing as they meander around the square. Phainon weaves through the crowd—waving at friendly faces, smiling at distant acquaintances—and forges ahead towards the clothing stalls.

Something tugs his coat. Phainon immediately stops, heart jolting in his chest. Mydei stands stiff as a board next to him, close enough that Phainon can see the paleness on his face, his eyes darting this way and that like he isn't sure what to focus on—isn't sure what's a threat. His hand grips Phainon's coat tight enough to whiten his knuckles.

Phainon's fingers twitch. He glances around, then presses a hand against Mydei's back. Mydei tenses, but doesn't shake him off. Phainon slowly guides them towards the side of the street.

He bends down until he's eye-level with Mydei, scanning his expression. Gently, he places his hands on Mydei's shoulders. Mydei's breath quickens, his hands shooting out to grip the front of Phainon's shirt.

"Are you alright?" Phainon whispers, crowding into Mydei's space until he's the only thing Mydei can see.

Mydei's jaw clenches. Slowly, he nods his head, eyes pinned on him, gaze shaky.

"I'm sorry," Phainon murmurs. "We're almost at the stall. As soon as we buy you some clothes, we'll leave the market, okay?"

Mydei's next exhale shudders through his body. He squeezes his eyes and nods.

"If you're worried about getting lost, I can hold your hand," Phainon offers. "I promise I won't let anything happen to you."

Mydei's hands clench tighter around his shirt. Phainon watches Mydei swallow roughly, then nod again.

"Okay," he says, the word thin.

Phainon exhales.

"Okay." He slowly rises. Mydei releases his shirt, only to grab his coat. He gingerly disentangles one of Mydei's hands to slip it in his—jarred by how small it is. Phainon presses his lips together,

shuffling closer to the other. “Whenever you’re ready, we’ll head to the clothing stall.”

“We can go now,” Mydei says immediately.

Phainon blinks. His hand unconsciously tightens around Mydei.

“Okay.”

He leads them back into the main part of the market, feeling the other’s grip tighten as soon as they’re back in the crowd. Mydei stays close, eyes pinned forward and entirely unfocused. Phainon glances at the blank expression on his face, then urges them around a slower-moving family towards the edges of the market.

“Good morning, Arachne,” he greets, catching the attention of the young woman running the stall.

“Lord Phainon!” She greets, beaming. “Good to see you.”

“You as well.” He inclines his head. “We’re in a bit of a rush today. Do you happen to have any clothes fitting for a child around six or so?”

“We?” Arachne’s eyes scan around Phainon, confused, before landing on Mydei. She gasps. “Is that Lord Mydei?”

Mydei tenses, squeezing his hand. Phainon pulls him closer to his side.

“Indeed. It happens when he’s recovering from too many deaths at a time,” Phainon lies smoothly. “It’s why I need clothes for a child, Miss Arachne.”

“Is Lord Mydei alright in that state?” Arachne asks, worry softening her expression. Phainon smiles, reassuringly, attempting to bring her attention away from Mydei.

“He’s fine. His healing has simply been working overtime for too long,” he says. “He needs rest, and preferably, a better set of clothes.”

Arachne’s eyes flicker to his clothes. A funny expression pinches her face, like she’s trying not to laugh.

“Of course,” she says stiffly. “Let me bring out my selection.” Arachne hurries further into the stall, busying herself with one of her chests.

Phainon glances down at Mydei. His eyes are lowered, staring at the ground like he’s trying to pretend he’s anywhere but here. Phainon frowns, glances around, and brightens, a store a few doors down catching his eye.

He shakes Mydei’s hand. Mydei’s head jerks up, body tense.

“Sorry,” Phainon murmurs. “After we’re done here, we can get a small treat.”

“What?”

“A treat.” Phainon tilts his head towards Marmoreal Diner. “That place sells honey cakes. You like having them every once in a while.”

“What’s a honey cake?”

Phainon opens his mouth, hesitates, then closes it.

“I’ll show you once we’re done here,” he promises.

“I’ve got a few tunics and slacks in stock, Lord Phainon.” Arachne sets down a stack of neatly folded clothes. “I can also find some chlamys for Lord Mydei as well.”

“We’ll go with the black tunic and pants, and a red chlamys if you have one,” Phainon says, “unless you want something else, Mydei?”

Mydei jerkily shakes his head.

He pays for the clothes, then guides them over to Kyros’. They order a golden honey cake to share, and Phainon leads Mydei out of Marmoreal Market down a quieter side street. The farther they walk from the marketplace, the more Mydei sheds his caution—no longer pressed against his side but walking a comfortable distance away, his hand still firmly grasped in Phainon’s.

They stop in a little park. Phainon leads them to an empty bench and cracks open the lid, handing Mydei a fork.

“A prize for accompanying me to the market,” Phainon says, cutting the cake into bite-sized pieces. “Try it.”

Just like with the fruits and the dinner yesterday, Mydei slowly inches his fork over—wary and shy. He stabs a piece, twirls the fork in his hand, then cautiously bites into it.

His expression lights up like the sun. Phainon laughs.

“Is it good?”

Mydei swallows.

“Yes.” He pauses, lowers his eyes, and murmurs, “Thank you, Phainon.”

Phainon stops, chest suddenly warm.

“My pleasure.” His hand moves without thinking, gently ruffling Mydei’s hair.

This time, Mydei stiffens, but does not move away.

He spends the rest of the day showing Mydei around as much of Okhema as possible—from the Kephale Plaza to the Dromas stables to the Garden of Life and everything in between. Phainon guides them down side paths between destinations, avoiding the crowds that gather during Action Hour. And once they’ve tired themselves out, he leads them back to Marmoreal Palace for a bath—Mydei’s hand still in his.

As it turns out, Mydei wants nothing to do with the Hero's Bath.

"We need to get you washed up, Mydei," Phainon pleads.

"No."

"Please?"

"No."

"Don't you want to get out of that yellow and purple outfit?"

Mydei's expression twists into a scowl, glancing at his clothes, then the water. Phainon himself has already stripped down to his smallclothes, the water just barely reaching above his knees.

"It's *your* fault that I'm wearing clothes in the first place," he accuses.

"Yes, well, I'm trying to help you get out of them too, aren't I?"

Mydei's eyes narrow, his scowl growing more severe. At his sides, his hands are clenched into fists —shaking the slightest bit. Phainon watches them tremble, his frown deepening, and… well. He should've known—especially at this age, especially now for Mydei.

"The water won't hurt you," Phainon murmurs, moving closer to Mydei. Mydei shies away—fear and anger tightening his spine. "It's not deep enough to, Mydei. I promise."

His eyes flicker to the water, staring at the ripples. He shakes his head profusely.

Phainon sighs.

"You trusted me to keep you safe in the market, right?" he asks. "Trust me again that I won't let anything happen to you, Mydei. I promise."

Mydei's gaze flits to him, and the fear is so clear and so eerily similar to that same fear Mydei had just before Oronyx's mechanism shifted into place.

Phainon falters, struck dumb by how much Mydei hasn't changed from his childhood, just before he remembers *whose* fault it is that Mydei's in this state in the first place. Fearful of touch, fearful of crowds, anticipating pain before any other sensation—it's a wonder the Mydei *he* knows trusts anyone, much less him: the person who gets him into half the messes he encounters.

Once again, Mydei's forced to deal with the fallout of Phainon's messes.

"Phainon?"

Phainon blinks. He glances back at Mydei. The fear in his eyes is gone, replaced with a look of discomfort.

"Are you okay?" Mydei asks, his tone tinged with worry even while his gaze awkwardly shifts between Phainon and anything else. Phainon huffs a laugh.

"I'm okay," he says. "Just thinking."

Mydei frowns. He glances at the water, presses his lips into a thin line, and slowly lifts his shirt. His trousers come off next, both neatly folded and placed on the kline next to a stack of towels. Then, Mydei shuffles over, takes a deep breath, and steps into the bath.

He flinches the moment his foot touches the water, brows furrowing.

“It’s warm,” he murmurs.

“It’s supposed to be relaxing,” Phainon says, lowering himself on the bench in the bath. “These waters are blessed by Phagousa. They’re supposed to be healing.”

He beckons Mydei over. Mydei bites his lip, then slowly treads his way over.

“Let me help you wash yourself.”

Mydei stiffens the moment Phainon extends his hand. Phainon immediately retracts.

“I can do it myself,” Mydei mutters.

He exhales, forcing a smile on his face.

“Alright.”

They clean themselves in silence—Mydei’s movements cautious while he sinks further into the bath. Phainon pretends not to notice him staring while he lathers the soap bar in his hands and scrubs his body. When he hands the bar over to Mydei, the other takes it in his hands and awkwardly tries to mimic his movements.

“Are you sure you don’t want help?” Phainon offers again, watching Mydei struggle to wash his back. He hears Mydei’s breath catch—even above the sound of water. “At least with your hair and your back.”

Mydei looks over his shoulder at Phainon, expression discomfited. Phainon bites the inside of his cheek and slowly moves closer.

“I understand if you don’t feel comfortable,” he says, smiling ruefully. “I’ll stop asking if you don’t want my help. You don’t seem to like being touched.”

Hyacine had been fine though, for some reason, and the thought lingers on his mind like a shadow.

“I’m… not used to it,” Mydei admits quietly. He stares at the bar of soap in his hands, then back at Phainon. “Before, if I was touched, I died soon after.”

Phainon winces. Mydei looks back down at the bar of soap, then hesitantly offers it to Phainon.

“You won’t hurt me?” he asks, eyes guarded and bright. Phainon inhales sharply, chest squeezing tight.

“Titans, of course not,” he says, pained that he’d even imply such a thing. “I’d sooner hurt myself than let anything happen to you, Mydei.”

Mydei blinks, taken aback—eyes wide as he stares at him. Phainon sighs through his nose, then gently takes the bar of soap from his hands and beckons him closer.

“Sit. I’ll start with your back.”

It takes a moment for Mydei’s surprise to clear away. He catches Mydei’s throat bob as he sits—his back facing Phainon. Phainon lathers the soap, sets the bar down, and shifts closer.

“I'm going to put my hands on your shoulder, okay?”

Mydei nods, the action only slightly jerky.

Phainon rubs the soap over Mydei’s skin, scrubbing it on his back. He’s careful with his movements, slow enough that Mydei can move the moment he’s uncomfortable. Mydei shivers violently when Phainon’s hands skim his weak spot, but otherwise, he doesn’t react—stiff as a board but tolerating to his touch.

“Close your eyes,” Phainon murmurs. Mydei squeezes them shut. Phainon pours water over his head, soaking his hair and washing away the soap. He repeats two more times, before grabbing a towel and gently wiping his face.

He places his hands back on Mydei’s shoulders and gently squeezes the muscles there—his thumb pressing circular motions against his trapezius muscles, attempting to coax out the tension.

“What are you doing?” Mydei mumbles.

Phainon huffs wryly.

“Trying to help you relax.” He glances around, eyes catching on a bottle of olive oil, and pours a generous amount on his hands. “You tend to carry your stress here, on your shoulders.”

He presses his palms against Mydei’s back—easing a knot in his shoulders. Mydei shivers.

“Breathe,” Phainon murmurs. “I promise I won't hurt you. It’s the last thing I want to do.”

Mydei inhales shakily, then exhales—Phainon pressing firmer around his shoulders.

“Again.”

He breathes in again, smoother his time, the subsequent exhale sagging his shoulders with it. Phainon smiles.

“Your muscles tend to bunch up here, around your upper back,” he murmurs, pressing his palms along the span of Mydei’s back. “It’s always tight in this area, like you never learned how to relax.” He digs his thumb into the muscle. Mydei exhales—a small puff of air as his body slowly loosens.

“Did you do this a lot for big me?”

“Big you?”

Mydei nods, glancing back at Phainon. His eyes are clearer now—golden and soft like the color of the sunrises back in Aedes Elysiae. If Phainon didn’t know any better, he’d almost call them content.

He laughs, soft and ironic.

“Not as often as I would've liked,” he admits, gliding his hand up Mydei’s back. “You wouldn’t take me up on my offers most of the time.”

He rinses his hands in the bath water, then grabs the shampoo, pouring some into his hands.

“I'm going to wash your hair now.” Phainon shifts closer, then lathers the shampoo through Mydei’s hair, fingers skimming across his scalp.

He could probably count the number of times Mydei let him wash his hair on one hand. Very rarely is Phainon allowed to pamper him the way he wants—even when his immortal body is at its limit. Only when Mydei was truly out of it was Phainon allowed to take care of him in this capacity.

And yet, when it came to Phainon, there seemed to be no limit to how much Mydei enabled or indulged him. There wasn’t a limit to how much Mydei took care of him, and that imbalance unsettled him.

Bit by bit, Mydei’s breathing deepens. Phainon tilts Mydei’s head back, running water through his hair until all of the soap is out. Then, he presses his thumbs against the other’s temples, rubbing circles into them and soothing the tension. Mydei slumps, listing forward enough that Phainon hurries to ease him back so he’s leaning against his chest. He smiles, watching Mydei blink up at him, expression relaxed.

“Enjoying yourself, aren’t you?” he teases, chest squeezing hard enough to leave him breathless with affection. His hands comb through Mydei’s hair, carding through the strands. Mydei nods, the movement almost imperceptible, his cheeks coloring an endearing shade of pink.

“What was on your mind earlier?” Mydei asks, his words quiet and drawled.

“Earlier?” He pauses. “You mean just before you entered the bath?”

Mydei nods.

Phainon purses his lips, then sighs.

“It’s nothing important,” he says, smiling. “Don't worry about it.”

Mydei frowns, but doesn’t seem to have the will to argue. Instead, his eyes slip shut again—a small sigh leaving his lips. Phainon’s chest burns, feeling almost giddy with his affection. He continues his ministrations, gently massaging Mydei’s temples down to his nape, feeling the other melt further and further into him. A heavy feeling curls in his gut. He feels greedy—possessive of the trust Mydei has finally handed him, unknowing or not.

He curls his body around Mydei, wraps his arms, and holds him tight. Miraculously, Mydei doesn't flinch—only presses closer.

Mydei has another nightmare in the middle of Curtain-Fall Hour, this one leaving him shaking and sobbing. Phainon’s quick to react, gently shaking him awake and murmuring helpless words of comfort.

He wakes faster this time, eyes wet and dazed. His hands weakly tug on Phainon's shirt, pulling him closer. The moment Phainon slips into bed, Mydei curls tight around him—hands gripping his shirt, face pressed against his sternum. Phainon feels tears press against his skin and wraps his arms tight around Mydei, rubbing his back and stroking his hair, whispering weak assurances and empty platitudes until Mydei's breathing deepens again.

He holds Mydei close until Lucid Hour comes.

Castorice and Trinnon return to Okhema midway through Lucid Hour. Aglaea wastes no time summoning him and Mydei to the Hero's Bath the moment they arrive.

"Little Cas and I found the miracle orb Snowy and De ran into," Trinnon says, passing her teleslate around with pictures of the orb.

"This miracle orb is a subset of the ordinary ones we usually see," Castorice explains. "It's a more powerful conduit than normal miracle orbs—allowing people to grant longer blessings and cast life-changing curses."

"Is there a way to reverse the effects?" Aglaea asks.

Castorice purses her lips and shakes her head.

"Lady Trinnon and I couldn't find anything of note on the miracle orb about reversing the effects," she says. "But, we both figured we could always try to use this same miracle orb on Lord Mydei again. This time, with an experienced user of Oronyx's blessings."

Aglaea crosses her arms, eyes narrowed in thought. Phainon chances a glance at Mydei, the other sitting stiffly at his side. Gently, he nudges his leg. Mydei's eyes flicker to him for less than a second before flickering back to Castorice, Trinnon, and Aglaea—his wariness unchanged.

Phainon sighs.

The elevator leading up to the Hero's Bath suddenly rises. Hyacine appears, hurrying over towards their little group with Little Ica fluttering behind her.

"Sorry, I'm late," she says in lieu of a greeting. She waves at all of them, beaming widely when her eyes meet Mydei's. Next to him, Mydei smiles shyly back. "I was just on a call with Professor Anaxa. I think he has some insight into Little De's predicament."

Aglaea raises a brow.

"Anaxagoras?" she asks. "What could he possibly have to say about a Titan's power?"

"Quite a bit, Lady Seamstress," Anaxa's tinny voice sneers from Hyacine's teleslate. Hyacine fiddles with her screen and turns the teleslate over—revealing Anaxa's unamused expression. "Enough to say I believe I know what sort of magic that Titan wrought upon our little prince."

"And here I thought you were only interested in your heretics."

“Only a fool would refuse to learn about their opposition.”

“What’s wrong with Mydei, Professor?” Phainon interrupts. Anaxa squints at him, eyes flicking over to Mydei. Next to him, Mydei stiffens.

“Fascinating,” Anaxa murmurs. “Hyacine said even his memories have been altered.

“That’s correct,” Phainon confirms. He taps his fingers against his thigh, impatient.

Anaxa hums. He strokes his chin, watching Mydei.

“Professor Anaxa—”

“Anaxagoras.”

“—what’s wrong with Mydei?” Phainon repeats. He wraps an arm around Mydei’s back, gently coaxing him to relax. Mydei flinches, but doesn’t move away.

“I heard you the first time,” Anaxa says, waving his hands. “Mydeimos hasn’t been afflicted with anything harmful. Even I can admit Oronyx is a friendly titan with a child-like disposition. All they want is for people to get along. If they cast a curse on someone, it is because they believe it will help them in the long run. Like, for example, turning them into a child to make them more honest.”

“You believe Lord Mydei is lying about something?” Castorice asks, brows furrowing. “That doesn’t seem like him.”

“Mydei doesn’t lie,” Phainon agrees firmly.

“You misunderstand,” Anaxa says, frowning. “Phainon, my assumption is that you and Mydeimos were likely arguing near the miracle orb—angry enough that it disturbed Oronyx. The Time Titan dislikes conflict, especially ones rooted in misunderstanding or false pretenses. When Mydeimos activated the mechanism, it allowed them to cast a blessing and reverse time on him. Perhaps they believe Mydeimos wasn’t being honest with you in that fight. After all, there is nothing more honest than a child.”

“Mydei seemed pretty honest with me while we were fighting,” Phainon says, almost bitter. “I don’t think he was lying when he said he believed I should just let him die to save myself.”

“Snowy.”

Phainon turns to Trinnon, tilting his head curiously.

“You were the one who activated the miracle orb, not De, right?”

He nods.

“Maybe Oronyx had intended for you to turn into a child. It just happened that De ended up intervening,” she says. Phainon’s hand stills against Mydei’s back. Guilt curls its icy fingers around his chest. “There's something *you* need to be honest about, and that will break De’s affliction.”

“Phainon,” Aglaea starts, “would you mind recounting your fight with Mydeimos again?”

“Yeah,” Phainon says, tone quiet. “We got ambushed, and I took a blow that would've been lethal for him. Mydei got angry at me for risking my life for his. I thought Mydei was stupid for thinking I’d let him die like that.” He is painfully aware of the small warmth at his side, tucked under his arm. Selfishly, he rests his hand on Mydei’s waist and pulls him closer. “And then, I accidentally activated the miracle orb.”

“Do you have any sort of inkling of what Oronyx wanted you to be honest about?” Aglaea asks.

“Or perhaps something you were omitting?” Anaxa adds.

He bites the inside of his cheek. His eyes flicker to Mydei. Mydei looks up at him, his amber eyes large and piercing. He’s so much smaller than the Mydei he knows, so different and yet, so similar—newly scarred from the Sea of Souls, but still tough enough to raise himself. Even though he doesn’t have to—even when he *shouldn’t* have to. And Phainon…

His hand flexes uselessly in his lap. He wets his lip and looks away, a frown pinched on his expression. The Mydei he knows is reliable—has never faltered—his shoulders broad enough to wear the mantle of his past and carry the weight of his legacy. This younger version of Mydei is almost no different.

Phainon almost wishes he were, though.

“I don’t remember,” he lies. Aglaea’s eyes narrow.

“In that case, I believe we should try Castorice’s idea,” Aglaea says. She gives him a pointed look, eyes hazy and knowing. “If Phainon cannot remember what Oronyx wanted him to be honest about, then our only choice is to wield their power to revert Mydeimos back to his original state.”

Phainon bites his lip.

“Alright,” he says. “Mydei and I can head out at the first quint of Action Hour.”

Aglaea nods.

“We can accompany you, Snowy, De,” Trinnon offers. “We want to help little De turn back to big De.”

“That’s much appreciated, Lady Trinnon,” Phainon says.

“A shame you can’t remember what Oronyx wanted you to admit,” Anaxa drawls from Hyacine’s teleslate screen. Phainon winces.

“I agree with Anaxagoras, unfortunately,” Aglaea says. Anaxa rolls his eye. “Honesty seems to be the easiest way to lift this curse. If it comes to you, Phainon, consider telling Mydeimos what it is like Oronyx intended.”

“Noted,” Phainon says, smile thin.

“You haven’t changed your bandages.”

“What?” Phainon turns, glancing at Mydei striding towards him, his first-aid kit in hand.

“Lady Hyacine said you need to change your bandages every day.” Mydei sits at the kline and pops open the first aid kit, watching him expectantly.

“I’m almost healed, Mydei. I can change my own bandages.”

“You promised I could change them for you next time,” Mydei argues.

Phainon opens his mouth, pauses, closes it, and sighs.

“Alright, alright,” he concedes, moving to sit next to Mydei. He raises his shirt high enough for his bandages to show. “I guess I did say that.”

Mydei’s expression brightens, looking adorably self-satisfied. He pulls out a pair of scissors and starts unwrapping the bandages. Phainon watches him, expression fond and chest warm. He’s a little rough pulling off the tape, but otherwise, Mydei works gently, brows furrowed in concentration.

His wound is fully scabbed over now and smaller than before. Still, Mydei pulls out the disinfectant and carefully wipes around the wound. Then, he applies Hyacine’s salve, pouring an excess amount out and slathering it all over Phainon’s side like he’s a canvas.

“You don’t need to use that much, Mydei,” Phainon says, amused. “My wound doesn’t hurt enough to warrant this amount.”

Mydei frowns.

“Are you lying?” he asks.

Phainon blinks.

“Lying?”

“You lied to Lady Aglaea at the meeting,” Mydei murmurs. He wipes his hands on a rag, then takes out the medical tape and starts cutting uneven strips of tape. “You know what Oronyx wants you to say.”

“Oh.” Phainon purses his lips, biting the inside of his cheek. “I was just… embarrassed, really. I didn’t want to say it in front of everyone.”

Mydei’s frown deepens.

“It’s about me, isn’t it?” Myde pulls out a gauze pad and doesn’t meet Phainon’s eyes as he presses it against Phainon’s wound. “The thing the Time Titan wanted you to be honest about. It’s about me.”

“Not really,” Phainon admits. “It’s more… related to my own anxieties. It just felt too personal to say it with everyone around.”

“Why can’t you say it now then?” Mydei asks. “It’s just the two of us here.”

Phainon doesn't respond. The gauze pad isn't centered on his wound; Mydei taped it down too far to the left. When Mydei starts wrapping the bandages around his torso, he can tell immediately that he's wrapping them too loosely. He thinks about how, even now, he's still relying on Mydei—always relying on Mydei.

"You were always better at being honest with yourself than I was, Mydei," he admits. "And I'm terrified of too many things to admit certain truths, even to myself."

They set out for the Abyss of Fate at the top of the hour, one dromas shared between the three of them. Trinnon sits at the front, hands on the reins as she steers the dromas, while Phainon keeps watch in the back. Evernight darkens the path to the Abyss, putting him on edge. He can tell Mydei is faring no better, shoulders bunched tight. Phainon shifts closer so Mydei's tucked against his chest and keeps his eyes focused on the forest line.

They're barely halfway to the Abyss of Fate when the dromas suddenly stops—shuffling its feet and growling at nothing. Phainon tenses, gaze flickering over the shadows of the trees around them. He glances at Trinnon and Mydei before slowly dismounting the dromas and drawing Dawnmaker.

His feet land soundlessly on the ground. Phainon waits, eyes narrowed.

An arrow zips past, aimed straight for his chest. Phainon lifts his blade and blocks it with the flat side of the blade, then swings, cutting through a black tide creature aimed for his side. More of them appear from the shadows, surrounding them entirely. He counts a little more than ten monsters and scowls.

They charge towards them. Phainon meets them in the middle, sweeping his greatsword in a wide arc and sending a group of them back. He crosses blades with a tide-eroded blade, kicking it in its solar plexus before parrying an ax-wielder's swing behind him. The monster growls. Phainon thrusts straight into the creature's chest, watching it disintegrate, and turns around just in time to see a black tide monster collide with another.

He whips his head, catching Mydei dig his gauntlets into the chest of another black tide creature and discard the corpse. Mydei's eyes flick to him for a split second before his attention is caught by another monster. Phainon glances behind him and locks blades with a sword-wielder, disarming them before stabbing their core. He lifts the corpse to slow the swing of an ax and sweeps his leg low—tripping the ax-wielder before driving his blade in their throat.

And then, he hurries to Mydei's side.

"Stay close to me," Phainon shouts, pushing the creatures farther back when he swings his greatsword in a wide arc around them. His eyes flick to Mydei, heart in his throat and blood roaring. Gold stains Mydei's clothes like stars on the black clothing. Mydei looks at him, expression set, then charges at the remaining creatures without abandon—Phainon hurrying after him.

He stops a blade aimed for Mydei's side, allowing Mydei to grip the monster's head and twist his neck. He blocks an arrow for Mydei with Dawnmaker, letting Mydei grip the archer and tear them

apart. He stabs a daemon before they can strike Mydei, while the younger one throws a kick at a lurking black tide creature. He doesn't remember Mydei ever fighting with such disregard for himself. But, he supposes he only ever fought with Mydei after he had learned a sense of self-preservation.

The way this younger version of Mydei fights frightens him. He fights like he has nothing to lose and thousands of lives to throw away.

Phainon redirects an axe aimed for Mydei's head and kicks the creature away. He strikes a tide-eroded blade before the monster can stab Mydei. He's so focused on Mydei and the black tide creatures surrounding him that when he looks up, he registers the bone-chilling fear in Mydei's expression before he hears the black tide monster behind him.

A sickening sense of deja vu hits him when Mydei collides into him, pushing him out of the blade's trajectory. In the split second before the blade strikes true, Phainon thinks, hysterically, that this was how it started—him in Mydei's place, Mydei in his.

The nauseating squelch of a blade cutting through flesh roars in Phainon's ears. Mydei's tiny body convulses on the blade, golden blood spilling from his mouth like a rushing river. His eyes flutter. Phainon thinks he screams, but he's not sure. All he feels is the burning heat in his chest every time he's harnessed the power of the coreflames and the phantom sensation of wings on his back.

He just barely has the sense of mind to protect Trinnon and the dromas from the strike before he summons a meteor on the area.

When the dust settles, the black tide creatures are long gone. Mydei lies prone at his feet. Phainon drops to his knees, hands shaking as they flutter over Mydei's body, the golden blood stark against the black. His throat constricts, his chest tightening to the point of pain. Even now… even now, he can't protect Mydei when it matters.

He forces himself to suck in a harsh, guttural breath. He digs his nails hard into the flesh of his palm until the pain grounds him. Carefully, he slips his hands underneath Mydei's still form, lifting his small body and cradling him tight against his chest. Already, the wound has stopped bleeding, Mydei's skin slowly knitting itself back together.

He looks back at Trinnon still sitting on the dromas, hands clutched together like in prayer.

"Lady Trinnon," he murmurs, voice hoarse, "would you mind opening a century gate to Okhema?"

Trinnon nods. Phainon holds Mydei closer—feeling like he can't hug him tight enough.

"Century gate, open."

"We'll let Agy know what happened," Trinnon says, voice soft. She pats Mydei's head, gently combing her hands through his hair. Phainon holds him tighter. "We're sorry we couldn't help you, Snowy."

“It's alright, Lady Trinnon,” he murmurs. “You opened the gate and brought us back safely. That’s enough.”

Trinnon frowns. Her tiny hands brush back Mydei’s hair from his face.

“De will be alright, right?” she asks, quiet.

Phainon smiles weakly and nods.

“He’ll be back soon.”

Trinnon’s frown deepens.

“We’ll head to Marmoreal Palace first, then,” she says, lifting her head.

“Alright,” he says. “Fly safe, Lady Trinnon.

Trinnon nods, waves goodbye, then turns and flies towards the Palace. Phainon stands there for a moment, watching her become smaller and smaller. He glances down. Mydei’s wound is almost fully healed now—an ugly red cut rather than the gaping hole it was before.

He swallows roughly and enters Okhema proper.

The city is quiet at this time of day—sparsely populated when they’re so close to the boundary line. People flit past his peripheral vision, waving him by or greeting him hello. Phainon offers empty smiles, but he doesn’t stop walking—desperate to get home.

Mydei stirs in his arms just as they leave Kephale Plaza. It makes Phainon pause in his step, breath hitching harshly in his chest. He waits, arms tightening when Mydei shudders through a gasp. His eyes flutter open, hazy and disoriented and the brightest shade of gold.

Phainon presses his lips into a thin line. He lowers his head and holds Mydei tight.

“Phainon?” Mydei mumbles. His voice is so small, so young. Phainon feels himself shake. He pressed Mydei closer, tucking his head against the hollow of his neck.

“Titans, Mydei.” His fingers slip in Mydei’s hair, cradling his head. “I’m sorry. I’m so, *so* sorry.”

“For what?” Mydei’s hands grip his coat. He shifts in his arms like he’s trying to pull back. Phainon feels himself physically lurch.

“For letting you get hurt. For letting you die.” He’s not sure what sort of expression he’s making, but it’s enough to give Mydei pause when he leans far enough back to meet Phainon’s eyes—brows furrowing in worry.

“But I can't die.”

Phainon stares. He laughs—short and incredulous, anger stoking in his gut like the spark of a fire. Is it truly that hard to believe Phainon would rather not see Mydei die? Much less because of him?

“That’s not the point,” he says, sharper than he intends, rougher than he wants. “That was never the point, Mydei. I don’t *care* that you can’t die when every one of your deaths still hurts like you did.”

He starts walking again, brisker this time, winding through the side streets of Okhema, avoiding the market as he makes his way to the Palace. He feels unsettled, his body shaking with untapped energy and the need to do something before he loses his composure.

“I can walk on my own,” Mydei says, voice small.

Phainon’s brow twitches.

“I know you can.”

He doesn’t stop. Mydei squirms in his arms.

“Put me down.”

“Mydei,”—he stops in the middle of the road and holds Mydei’s gaze—“*you* might not care when you die, but other people do. *I* do. *I* care that you died not even a quint ago. So please, let me have this so I can feel a little less useless that you had to die because of me.”

He starts walking again, slower this time. He chews on his lip, shoulders drawn tight.

“Why?”

“What?”

“Why do you care?” Mydei asks.

“Why do I—” His steps falter, incredulous. “Mydei, I care because I care about *you*. I care that you aren’t hurt, that you aren't suffering. I care that you’re happy and healthy, which means I’d rather not see you wounded or killed. That's why I want to take care of you—why I’ve been *trying* to take care of you even when you don't trust me to.”

“But you never let others take care of you either,” Mydei cries, lips twisting into something distraught. Phainon blinks. “You never say what you feel. You *lie* to make me feel better.”

“When have I lied?”

“Every time your wound hurts,” Mydei says, his small hands fisting Phainon’s coat. “You always tell me you’re fine, even when I know you aren’t. How can I trust you to take care of me when you don’t take care of yourself and won’t let me do it for you?”

“But you *do* take care of me. That’s the problem.”

Mydei flinches, eyes wide. Phainon swallows roughly. What is he doing, fighting with a child because he can’t wrestle with his own insecurities? He squeezes his eyes shut and takes a deep breath, letting the exhale of it loosen his shoulders too. His fingers twitch against Mydei—desperate for something to grip, to pull.

“You don’t know, because you don’t remember, but I rely on you—older you—for… almost everything, Mydeimos.” He sighs, then meets Mydei’s eyes again, mouth pinched into a frown. “Older you is just as hyper-independent, just as tough, just as unrelenting as you are now. And it’s comforting to have you by my side, to know I can rely on you. I just wish you’d let me be the same for you, Mydei. That you’d rely on me too, so I can feel like I’m not just a dead weight next to you—that I deserve that spot by your side.”

He lets a wry smile pull on his lips, a humorless chuckle leaving him. Mydei is completely still in his arms, blinking at him in surprise.

“That’s probably what Oronyx wanted me to be honest about,” he says. “That’s why I was so… angry at you in the first place. Because you could sacrifice yourself a million times to me—*for* me—and each time, you’d always expect me to be fine with it. But the moment I do the same, you’re scolding me for my recklessness—as if I haven’t shouted at you for the exact same things.”

Mydei lowers his head. He feels Mydei loosen his grip on his coat, then start tracing the seams, hands fiddling with the metal clasp. He looks uncharacteristically cowed, like he doesn’t know how to handle this. Phainon shuts his eyes, takes a deep breath, and exhales until his skin no longer feels like it’s crawling.

“It’s a little ironic, this whole situation, you know?” he murmurs. “I was the one who should’ve been hit with Oronyx’s curse. But you were instead, and it was still just as effective in completing that Titan’s agenda. If not, more so.”

“What do you mean?” Mydei asks, his words barely louder than a whisper.

“You’re a child, Mydei,” he says. “And you still won’t let me take care of you.”

Mydei’s head ducks further, his hands pulling on the metal of his coat clasp. He doesn’t respond. Phainon sighs and smiles, even though he knows Mydei won’t see.

“Ah, well. It doesn’t matter,” he says, rueful. “I won’t force you to accept something you don’t want.”

He crouches down, loosening his grip. Mydei jerks and grabs his coat—yanking hard enough to stretch the fabric. He buries his face in the crook of Phainon’s neck and clings, tucking himself small against Phainon’s chest like he’s trying to hide. Phainon hurries to adjust his grip before Mydei chokes him or sends them both toppling, and Mydei squirms impossibly closer.

“Mydei?”

His grip tightens.

“I’m not used to being cared for,” he admits softly, the words pressed against Phainon’s skin. Phainon’s next breath squeezes out of him, harsh and surprised. He wets his lips and tucks Mydei closer against him.

“Do you want me to stop?” Phainon asks. “You don't need to do this for my sake, Mydei.”

Mydei shakes his head. He curls against Phainon—as if attempting to make himself small.

“This is fine, right?”

“More than fine,” Phainon assures, rubbing Mydei’s back in soothing circles. Mydei shivers. “As long as you feel comfortable.”

Mydei doesn’t immediately respond. Instead, he breathes in deep. Phainon feels the exhale on his skin like a brand, feels the way Mydei relaxes into his touch—his guard completely down. Phainon holds his breath.

“Take us home?” Mydei whispers.

He exhales.

“Of course.”

He brings Mydei back to his chambers and prepares the bath in his room, forgoing the Hero’s Bath. They could visit Phagousa’s blessed waters later, when he’s less shaken and Mydei less vulnerable.

Phainon helps Mydei undress, then guides him into the water. He scrubs away the remaining golden blood caked on Mydei’s skin and the grime from the black tide, drains the water out, and fills the bath again. Mydei is quiet the entire time, staring at Phainon with a level of trust that almost scares him, compared to how he’s acted only yesterday—compared to how Mydei’s acted with him the whole time they’ve known each other.

But who is he to complain when Mydei looks the most comfortable Phainon’s ever seen him?

He lets Mydei rest in the bath until his fingertips wrinkle and he starts dozing off. Phainon towels him dry and dresses him in an extra pair of clothes they bought from Arachne, then carries him down to the kitchen. He cooks a quick meal for the two of them, letting Mydei sit pressed against his side while they eat.

“You didn’t seem comfortable with touch just yesterday,” Phainon hedges. “I’m not complaining, just curious.”

Mydei’s gaze flicks to him before he lowers it, looking almost embarrassed.

“You’re very warm,” Mydei admits. “The Sea of Souls was cold.”

Phainon bites his tongue. He wraps his arms around Mydei then, hand settling on his waist, thinking he’d kill before he let someone take Mydei away.

Krateros is waiting at the door to Mydei’s chambers when they return, foot tapping impatiently against the stone floor. His eyes soften immediately when they land on Mydei, and harden when they meet Phainon’s.

Phainon stills, heart in his throat.

“The Prince is still in child form,” he says. “I believe that means it’s time I take him to the Kremnoan District.”

Phainon holds Mydei’s hand tighter. He opens his mouth to object.

“I want to stay with Phainon,” Mydei says.

Phainon and Krateros turn to Mydei. Mydei tenses, shifting closer to Phainon.

“You want to stay with him?” Krateros repeats.

Mydei nods. Krateros’ eyes grow stormy—conflicted. He looks like he’s about to argue with him, looks like he’s holding his tongue back from saying something harsh. A myriad of emotions flit past his expression before it flattens, resignation lowering the stiffness in his shoulders. If Phainon didn’t know better, he’d think Krateros looks regretful.

“As you wish, Your Highness.” He glances at Phainon, a severe expression on his face, then turns on his heels. His greaves click against the floor, and he doesn’t look back.

Phainon watches him go, purses his lips, then leads Mydei into his room.

“Can you stay here?”

“I’ve been here every night since you turned into a child,” Phainon says, smiling at Mydei. He pulls the covers, tucking him in.

“Not just in the room,” Mydei murmurs, eyes averting from Phainon’s gaze. He shifts farther in the bed, then lifts the covers on Phainon’s side.

Phainon’s mouth parts. He sheds his coat, then slips into bed next to Mydei. Mydei immediately scoots over, making himself small at Phainon’s side. Phainon wraps his arms around him, running a hand up and down his back.

“Sleep well, Mydei,” Phainon murmurs, pressing his lips to the crown of Mydei’s head. Mydei shivers, pressing impossibly closer.

He develops a fever in the middle of Curtain-Fall Hour. Phainon only knows because Mydei shivers so violently, it wakes him. And Phainon, half asleep and helpless, presses a hand to Mydei’s forehead and thinks, at least it isn’t nightmares again—at least he’s still sleeping soundly. Mydei’s skin burns under his touch, but he doesn’t seem to be in pain, and that's all Phainon can hope for right now.

He bundles him in the blanket, combing his hands through Mydei’s hair until the other stops shaking. He holds him close until his breathing deepens and he settles again, tucked in Phainon’s arms and close enough that he can feel his breath ghost across his collarbones. He stays up, exhausted and worried, waiting for *something*—good, bad, or otherwise—to happen.

Half a quint before Lucid Hour, Mydei's fever breaks—disappearing as quickly as it came. Phainon exhales, exhausted and weak with it. He passes out soon after, curled around Mydei's smaller frame like he's shielding him from the world's view.

The bed is warmer than Phainon remembers—smelling distinctly of the shampoo he used on Mydei's hair last night. Phainon sniffs and feels something tickle the tip of his nose. He squints his eyes open, arms tightening around the body next to him. Broad shoulders, blond hair, swirling red tattoos on a familiar back.

Phainon sucks in a sharp breath.

"Mydei!"

He shoots up and leans over—jostling the man next to him. Mydei's brows pinch, eyes still closed, expression disgruntled. Phainon traces Mydei's face with his eyes—his nose, his brows, his jawline, the lack of baby fat on his cheeks—and beams.

"Mydei." He shakes the other's shoulder. Mydei groans and half-heartedly swats at his hand. "Mydei. Mydei, you're not a child anymore! We broke Oronyx's curse!"

"You think I don't know that?" Mydei snips, voice hoarse and gravelly with sleep. He opens his eyes and glares—expression more peeved than angry. It makes Phainon laugh, all of it—pure relief spilling from the sound. He squeezes Mydei's shoulder, feeling oddly giddy.

"You were cuter as a child," Phainon says, lies, leaning his weight against Mydei's shoulder. Mydei rolls his eyes, lips curling up in a small smile. He presses his face more firmly into the pillow and closes his eyes. Phainon rests his chin on Mydei's shoulder, restless and happy. He forgot how warm Mydei is—full of power and life, strong in a way his younger self hadn't quite grown into yet. "I missed you, you know?"

"I never left," Mydei replies, eyes still shut.

"Your child self was missing a few decades of life experience. It wasn't exactly the same," Phainon murmurs. He glances down at Mydei's chest and trails a finger over the pattern of tattoos on his sternum. Irrationally, he wants to wrap his arms around Mydei and squeeze him tight, cut his own chest open and carve a space in it just big enough for Mydei only. "Do you even remember what happened the last two days?"

Mydei grunts, non-committal.

"You aren't being very forthcoming or friendly."

"It's too early for your questions, Phainon," Mydei shoots back drowsily. "Go back to sleep."

Phainon presses his smile against Mydei's shoulder. He shifts back, moving his arm from around Mydei's waist.

A hand grabs his wrist and yanks. Phainon yelps, pitching forward. He braces a hand on the bed and collides against Mydei's back. Mydei wraps Phainon's arm around his waist, settling Phainon's hand over his heart. Phainon raises a brow.

"What was that for?"

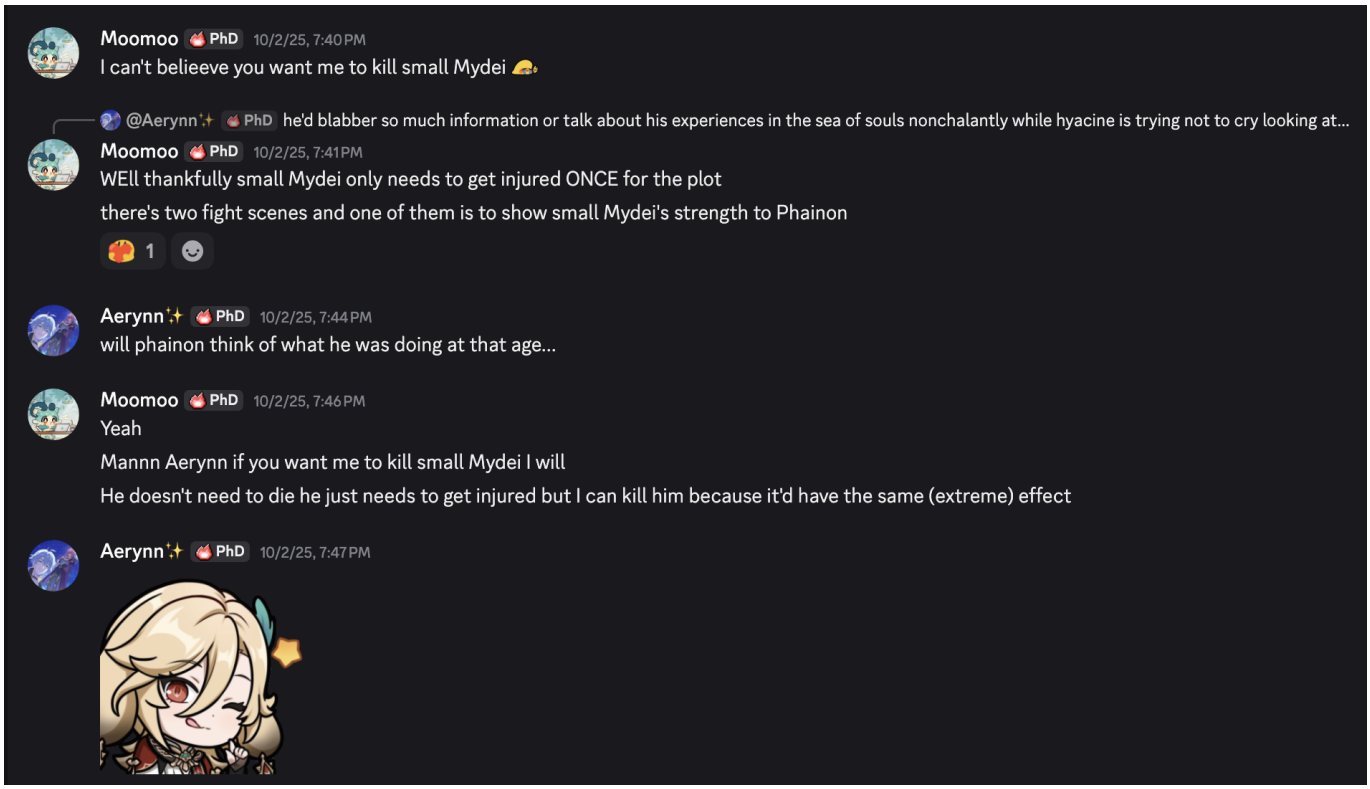
Mydei opens his eyes, head tilted to stare up at Phainon, and then averts his gaze. A light blush dusts the tips of his ears. Mydei's hand tightens over Phainon's.

"I told you to stay last night, didn't I?" Mydei says, eyes flickering back to his—almost accusatory. Phainon freezes, his cheeks burning. He watches Mydei close his eyes again and settle fully on the bed.

Phainon swallows roughly, unsure what to do with himself. He sinks back down on the bed, shifting forward until his chest is flush against Mydei's back—body curled around his. His arm tightens around Mydei. He buries his nose in his hair, feeling the other's chest rise and fall, his heart beating a steady rhythm, his hair smelling sweetly of olive oil and pomegranates.

He holds Mydei close as the morning dawns over them.

End Notes



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